I witnessed all this from the non-striker's end. When Allan came to fetch his cap from the umpire, I told him, 'Allan, Dodda only knows a local Indian language called Kannada. I find it difficult enough to communicate with him myself, so how can he understand your abuse in English? If you want to get to him, speak to him in Kannada.' This made Allan even more irritated. He almost snatched his cap from the umpire and, making wild gestures with his hands, stomped off to his fielding position.

By the end of the Cape Town match the players were much more used to the conditions and this augured well for us going to Johannesburg for the third Test. We were taking the game very seriously, even though it was a dead rubber. We played well from the start and Rahul Dravid, batting at number three for the first time in the series, scored a fantastic hundred. He played the fast bowlers late and helped us to a position of strength. Sourav too batted extremely well at number five and we scored 410 in our first innings, which put South Africa under pressure for the first time in the series. The bowlers followed up with a good effort to give us a handy first-innings lead.

In our second innings it was once again Rahul and Sourav who did the business. We could sense victory and were buoyed by the opportunity. Our bowlers prised out the South African top order fairly quickly. Even when there was a partnership between Daryll Cullinan and Lance Klusener for the eighth wicket, we knew we were within striking distance and just needed to keep plugging away.

We finally got our breakthrough, in the form of Klusener, and were just two wickets away from a hard-earned victory when the skies opened up. It was a torrential downpour and it soon became clear that we had lost a great opportunity to win a Test match in South Africa.

I was distraught. We had done everything we could to win the match and here we were being deprived by the rain. I felt cheated by the forces of nature. I went to the umpires as soon as the rain stopped and said we were ready to play even if the outfield was a little wet, but they were within their rights to say that they couldn't permit a restart unless the conditions were fit to play. The Test series ended 2–0 in favour of South Africa, but that scoreline didn't reveal just how close we had been to making it 2–1. It left me disconsolate and in my disappointment I locked myself in the bathroom and just cried.